

Information and consent form

Expert Consensus on an Open-Textbook for Theory Development Methodology (ECTO)

Introduction

Dear expert,

We are a research team from Erasmus University Rotterdam, led by me, Noah van Dongen, conducting a Delphi-based study on the creation of a textbook for teaching *scientific theory development and evaluation in psychology*. You are invited to participate as an *expert contributor* in a structured, multi-round consultation process. For more information, please read the project outline in our preregistration.

If any words or concepts are unclear, please contact us for clarification at any time. Participation is voluntary, and you may withdraw at any point without any explanation.

I will explain the study below. If you have any questions, please ask me.

If you want to participate in the study, you can indicate this at the end of this form. Participation is voluntary.

What is the research about?

The goal of this research is to collaboratively define and refine the skills, methods, and curriculum required to teach theory creation and evaluation in psychological science.

Through iterative Delphi rounds, participating experts will provide feedback and reach consensus on:

1. The essential *tasks of theorists*,
2. The *skills and learning goals* needed to perform them,
3. The *structure and content* of a textbook supporting these goals, and
4. The *assignments and assessment methods* appropriate for training students.

The study contributes to establishing a normative methodology for theory development and will result in an open-access textbook and at least one peer-reviewed methodological publication.

Why are we asking you to participate?

You have been selected because of your expertise in theory development, philosophy of science, computational modeling, or methodological education. Your perspective is essential for ensuring the textbook reflects diverse theoretical traditions and practices across psychology and related disciplines.

What can you expect?

- The Delphi process consists of around **12 online rounds** over approximately **12–18 months**.
- Each round involves completing an **online questionnaire** or **commenting on draft materials** (estimated **20 - 40 minutes per round**).
- Optionally, participants may take part in a **group discussion** or **follow-up interview** to clarify ideas.

All interactions occur **online** via secure platforms. At the end of each round, you will receive a summary of the results and the updated draft. All responses will be anonymized before being made publicly available. As a participant, you will be coauthor on all publications that result from this project. At any time until before submission, you can opt-out of this coauthorship.

You decide whether to participate

Participation is completely voluntary. Choosing not to participate or to withdraw later will have no negative consequences. You may stop participating at any time by informing the research team.

What are the potential risks and discomforts?

We do not anticipate any risks or discomforts related to participation. The topics concern scientific practices, not personal or sensitive matters.

What do you get for participating? / What are the benefits of participating?

There is no financial compensation for this study. However, participants will:

- be offered coauthorship in project publications and the textbook,
- Gain early access to the evolving materials, and
- Contribute to setting future standards for theory training and evaluation in psychology.

If you quit the study earlier, you will be acknowledged for the parts you participated in.

What data will I ask you to provide?

We will collect:

- Basic contact information (name, email address, institutional affiliation).
- Professional background (discipline, position, country).
- Your written responses and comments on draft materials.

Optional data includes demographic information (e.g., gender, career stage) to ensure diversity reporting.

No special or sensitive personal data (e.g., health, ethnicity, political or religious views) will be requested.

If interviews or group discussions are conducted, these will be audio-recorded for transcription purposes, with your consent.

Who can see your data? / What will happen to my data?

- Only the principal investigator and research assistants directly involved in the project will have access to identifiable data.
- Responses will be anonymized or pseudonymized before analysis and publication.
- Publications and open datasets will include only aggregated and anonymous information.
- If we wish to quote you directly or attribute ideas to you by name, we will ask for explicit consent beforehand.

How long will your personal data be stored?

- Personal and contact data will be stored securely on Erasmus University servers and **deleted within 12 months** after project completion.
- Anonymized research data (e.g., aggregated survey responses) will be retained for **10 years** after publication, in line with the EUR Research Data Management Policy.

Using your data for new research

- Anonymized data may be shared publicly on OSF (Open Science Framework) for educational and transparency purposes.
- Your data will not be traceable to you.
- If we wish to contact you again for future Delphi or follow-up projects, we will ask your permission below.

How will you receive the results of the study?

You will receive a summary of results after each round and a final report when the study concludes.

All final materials (e.g., textbook drafts, consensus summaries) will be openly available via the project's Zenodo page and Erasmus University repository.



Do you have questions about the study?

If you have any **questions** about the study or your privacy rights, such as accessing, changing, deleting, or updating your data, please contact me.

Name: Noah N.N. van Dongen
Phone number: +31 6 40875855
Email: n.n.n.vandongen@essb.eur.nl

Do you have a **complaint** or concerns about your privacy? Please email the Data Protection Officer (fg@eur.nl) or visit www.autoriteitpersoonsgegevens.nl. (T: +31 88 1805250)

Do you regret your participation?

During or after the study, you may regret your participation. Please indicate this by contacting me. I will then delete your data. Sometimes we need to keep some of your data so that, for example, the integrity of the study can be checked.

Once the textbook and/or article(s) are published, we cannot change the information included in it.

Ethics approval

This research has been reviewed and approved by an internal review committee of Erasmus University Rotterdam (approval number: ETH2526-0077). This committee ensures that research participants are protected. If you would like to know more about this RERC/IRB, please visit www.eur.nl/essb/English or contact ec-dpecs@essb.eur.nl

Declaration of Consent

I have read the information letter. I understand what the study is about and what data will be collected from me. I was able to ask questions as well. My questions were adequately answered.

By signing this form, I:

1. consent to participate in this research;
2. consent to the use of my personal data
3. confirm that I am at least 18 years old;
4. confirm that I understand that participating in this research is completely voluntary and that I can stop at any time;
5. confirm that I understand that anonymous data is used for publication, educational purposes and further research;

Check the boxes below if you consent to this.

Data about

I consent to the collection, retention of the following data: name, profession, gender, region, and email address.

☐

Audio recording

If interviews are desirable, I consent to the interview being audio recorded.

☐

Sharing of data outside the EEA

I consent to the sharing of my anonymized data on a public server, such as the Open Science Framework

☐

My answers in the article

I give permission for my answers to be used in papers, such as an article in a journal or book. My name will not be included.

☐

Use for educational purposes and other research

I consent to the use of my anonymized data for publication, educational purposes, and future research

☐

New research

I give permission to be contacted again for new research. My contact information will be kept for this purpose.

☐

Name:

Date:

Signature: